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r/cuboulder • 7d ago
great_equator



If you're moving into a dorm for the first time, read this.

I left home at 14 to live at a boarding high school (think almost identical to college, but with high school level classes and a curfew).

I'm currently a junior at CU, so in total, I have 6 full years of experience living in dorms. Ask me anything.

Below are also some takeaways and secret tips I've collected, which I wish I knew going into the whole thing. I also created a packing list below that, shaped from years of trial and error.

- You do not need a shower caddy or basket.

These are included in every college packing list. What actually happens is that you will have a dripping basket with no practical storage location, that will eventually get moldy. Instead, especially if you don't want to change your clothes in front of a roommate, just wrap your soap and stuff in the towel you're going to use, and walk to the bathroom in your clothes. Change there. Use your dirty clothes as a bathmat. Dry off the toiletries with the towel, wrap them up again, and go back.

- Don't put pillows on your bed that can't be put into a pillowcase.

I bought one of those armchair-like things for my bed for my first dorm. Not being able to have a fresh cover with the rest of my sheets every week ended up giving me acne. It is also totally unnecessary, because you can lean against your normal pillows just fine.

- Less is more.

You don't need to bring everything from your childhood bedroom, only things that you touch at least every month. Lightweight and efficient versions of everything are king for moves and traveling back home.

- You will need your keycard every time you leave, including to use the bathroom.

Don't make the mistake of going to shower and forgetting it, because if you don't have anyone to call or your roommate isn't there, you'll need to walk down to the main lobby in a towel and get a temporary key.

- Set a timer for your laundry on your phone so someone doesn't pull all your wet clothes out onto the floor in order to use it.

- Use your backpack to carry groceries if you're taking the bus to the store.

The Bound bus line goes straight from Will Vill to King Soopers (a local grocery store).

- A dish sponge or brush is a pain in the ass.

You won't have a sink to put it next to, and it'll get moldy, just like a shower caddy. I ate out of containers and washed dishes using my hand and paper towels.

- Yes, they can hear your music and your private phone call.

- Dispose of food using plastic bags.

There's usually no sink disposal, and flushing it down the toilet was a really stupid mistake I made in high school, because it caused a blockage.

- Ask for your roommate's schedule right away.

It's handy to know when they'll be around and when they won't.

- You're allowed to rearrange the furniture, and fully figure this out before you unpack.

It doesn't all have to be against the walls, but it largely depends on the size of the room and what furniture

[Skip to main content](#)[Log In](#)**- Don't buy a TV.**

It will be a huge pain while moving, and you probably won't have time to use it very much. I have always opted to sneak into a classroom or lecture hall, hook up my laptop to the projector, and get a full theater experience to watch sports or movies. Can also work with gaming.

- Dorm meetings aren't actually required.

Nobody will say anything or come after you if you don't go. I'd recommend it, though.

- The flashing thing on the ceiling is an occupancy sensor.**- Top floor of Stearns has a cool library.****- People screw around on common area furniture.**

The fabric will get you pregnant if you're not careful. There's also god knows how many ancient boogers embedded in them. Keep that in mind, especially during cold season.

- Don't get your keycard near magnets, including on the back of your phone.

My card stopped working in both high school and college because I stored it there.

- Pin a hat over the thermostat to prevent it from reading its own AC and turning off too soon, and hold an ice cube on the bottom to turn on the heat.

And here's a list of some stuff you'll actually need.

- For storing toiletries and clothes, get these three items.

For toiletries, get [one of these](#) hanging roll-ups. I can't exaggerate how efficient it made everything. Hang it in your closet or somewhere better, and use it for your place to put things like your body wash after showering. Using coathangers or the provided drawers will limit your storage. [Hanging shelves](#) are your best bet. These have survived me until now. There is also a trick for packing them. Instead of emptying out all your clothes from them, you can collapse them *with the clothes inside*, and fit them *perfectly* into one of [these](#) bags (which are also extremely useful for things like bedding). That way, you take them out again with your clothes all folded, organized, and ready.

- Little things you might forget about.

- Small trash bags
- Scissors
- Earplugs (Dorms are noisy. Will also make you lock in harder during exams when surrounded by people in an echoey lecture hall.)
- Ibuprofen/Tylenol (Keep these in your backpack, not in your room. A ziploc bag is good if you don't want your backpack to sound like you're bringing a maraca to class.)
- Thumbtacks
- Batteries
- Compact [baby stapler](#)
- Handheld [notepad](#) (Acts as index cards, sticky notes; your thing to frantically grab when writing down something being read off to you during a phone call.)
- Cold/flu meds (I guarantee you will get sick between October-December, then again between March-April). [Zicam](#) has saved me before.
- Tweezers
- Nail clipper ([this one](#) is nice if you don't want to put your foot up on a communal toilet.)

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[This](#) acts as your tupperware/lunchbox in addition to everything else you would need. Microwavable, light, and stored neatly as one compact item.

- Headlamp.

CU Boulder has more power outages than any other place I've lived in, and I don't know what I would have done without one.

- For cleaning and first aid, you can kill multiple birds with one stone.

Clorox wipes are not safe for surfaces that may have food touching them, whereas medical [isopropyl wipes](#) will evaporate immediately, leaving zero residue, and have just the same disinfecting power. Not to mention, they safely clean a wound. Instead of band-aids, get [turf tape](#). Same stuff band-aids use, but much cheaper, and can be cut to whatever size or shape you need, over a tissue or gauze. It'll also come in handy for anything you'd use duct tape for. [Aquaphor](#) will miraculously heal things overnight, and you'll certainly need it for chapped lips in Colorado. The tub of that size I got years ago has lasted me since.

- Easy-to-assemble floor lamp.

The overhead lights will be harsh and greenish, and will eliminate any possibility of coziness. Make sure to get one that will be bright enough to fill the room, so you can come back at night, turn it on, and be in a comfortable environment. I've had [this one](#) for all 6 years, and it's now happily in my apartment. Collapses away and is packed easily.

- Shop fan.

A tall rotating one will be annoying during moves. I ended up opting for a [proper shop fan](#), which can clamp onto edges, be hung on the wall or magnetically stuck on the side of the microwave, and is quite powerful.

- Portable door lock.

[Works for any door](#). Helps for study rooms that people have to open the door to see if it's occupied, which can be distracting.

- Lint roller.

Lifesaver for crumbs on the floor, loose hair on stuff, dust, and dirt. Saved me when I broke glass on the carpet, it picked up all the little shards. I regularly used it to clean the floor, and it does a better job than a swiffer. Also very useful for dusty surfaces. Get one of the [wide pet hair ones](#).

- Camping backpack with interior pockets.

I carry everything I may need, including lunch, sunscreen, deodorant, calculator, gloves for cold weather, whatever, in my backpack. A lightweight, resilient one with places to put tiny things inside will be a wise choice.

- Hamper bag, and detergent sheets.

You will probably have stairs to climb if you want to do laundry. Also, I had a bag of tide pods pop open during a move a few years ago, prompting me to switch to sheets. Much better.

- XL Twin sheets, pillowcases, blanket, and your own pillow.

Make sure you can wash the blanket, or if it's a comforter, put on a cover and wash that.

- Waterproof file folder.

Especially if you're bringing your birth certificate, you will need a place to put it, and you will also probably collect things like tax documents if you have a job. This protected important papers during the previously mentioned Tide Pod Explosion Incident of 2023.

- Ultralight towels instead of fluffy ones.

Fun fact, there are showers in some of the academic buildings, and you can shower at the campus gym (the

[Skip to main content](#)[Log In](#)**- Screwdriver with different attaching heads, and pliers.**

You are going to end up needing a [screwdriver](#). The different types of heads has been a big plus for things like repairs over the years, because dorms often use screws with unusual heads. There were also many times needle-nose [pliers](#) came in handy.

- Desk drawer tray.

You are going to have a desk drawer that will quickly fill up, and you'll probably put other, non-office stuff in there too. Getting one of [these](#) was a game-changer. Also nice because you just lift the whole thing out with everything in it, and then when you put it into your new desk (wherever it is), it's all ready for you.

↑ 128 ↓ · 12



Meizas • 7d ago

If I can add some things -

Get some Narcan to have on hand. Even if you don't use drugs, someone in the dorms inevitably does. If they take something laced with something else, everyone will be glad you have it.

Related to that, I agree absolutely about having a personal first aid kit with the essentials like ibuprofen, Pepto bismol, etc. As OP said, you will get sick sometime. The dorms are full of gross, sick people. Gross, sick people who then go kiss each other. Last year(?) like all my undergrad students got strep because it ravaged one of the dorms.

Okay, I know some innocent, sheltered freshman is going to read this and freak out - The fabric on the furniture can't *actually* get you pregnant, but just know those couches have SEEN THINGS. Horrible things.

Anyway. Great list. I disagree about using your hand and paper towels for dishes, but whatever works for you, I guess.

Love the "sneaking into classes for the projector" idea and am mad that in my ten years of college I've never once thought of doing that.

To add to the pillowcase thing - for the love of all that is good, if nothing else, wash your sheets and pillowcases regularly. I knew a guy who didn't wash them for a YEAR AND A HALF. He got a full body staph infection.

I'd add get some kind of a small compact multi tool like a Leatherman

I had a little lap desk for my laptop or to use as a small table and really liked it.

I agree with the hamper bag rather than a big physical one. People bring plastic ones and they always end up broken and jagged by the end haha - 100% agree with the bag

Eye masks and earplugs for sleeping too

⬇ 8 ⬆



great_equator OP • 7d ago

Lap desk is a great idea. Thanks for the additions!

↑ 1 ↓

[Skip to main content](#)[Log In](#)  2  **great_equator** OP • 6d ago

Just kidding for the sake of emphasis. Sperm cells die when it dries out, so nothing to worry about besides grossness.

 1 **KnowYourLimit69** • 7d ago

I agree with most of what you said except my shower caddy was probably the most useful item I had in my dorm. It would have been so much of a pain going to shower and having to carry shampoo, body soap, face soap, wash cloth or loofah or whatever you use, and for me toothbrush and toothpaste. Shower caddy was so useful, and they have holes all through them so water can get out and prevent mold. Used the same one all year as a freshman, and just put it on a towel in my closet and changed the towel often enough it didn't get nasty, but really not sure how mold would be a problem. Second is my roommate and I got a 50 inch TV for like \$95 at Costco and used it all the time. We played Xbox games together, had friends in our dorm to watch sports games and movies. And we often would watch YouTube videos or family guy or something before bed together. Was never a pain to deal with, and since TVs are so cheap nowadays we just donated it after a year of use.

  8  **No2Ael** • 2d ago

I'm seconding the shower caddy, I think the issue is you need one something not cloth and then don't keep it in a closet. Our air is so dry out here it's usually not a problem. I had this thing ages ago and worked great. <https://www.lowes.com/pd/DII-Shower-Caddy-Pink/1002863854> I also had a stupid little towel robe thing so I felt moderately less embarrassed when I inevitably forgot my room key and had to walk up to get a spare with dripping hair and no underwear. Also, shower shoes, keep them in the caddy and use them or you will get a weird wart.

 1 **Dragwhal** • 7d ago

This is a lot of good stuff, thanks

 13 **ReginaPhalange74** • 7d ago

Thank you for this! I was a CU student ages ago, but my son is about to head there in the fall. This is incredibly helpful information!

 10 **mindset_matter** • 7d ago

Fantastic list, A+

 9 **calliopemuse** • 7d ago

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... travel, too. Well done!

2



maliksmamma • 6d ago

Thanks for this info!

2



Top-Photograph5222 • 5d ago

Excellent!

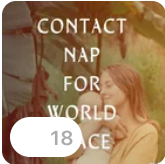
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r/bninfantsleep • 2mo ago

A reminder, in case you feel like you're doing nothing when you're contact nap trapped

125 upvotes · 8 comments



r/electricdaisycarnival • 2mo ago

If you still don't have EDC housing locked in, read this before you book anything

38 upvotes · 29 comments



r/GatedCommunitiesIndia • 3mo ago

Before you go for site visits this weekend, read this first.

14 upvotes · 4 comments

PROMOTED

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Homebuyers, Before you go for site visits this weekend, Read this first.

17 upvotes · 8 comments



r/onguardforthee • 6d ago

Nearly all Canadian universities fall in global rankings

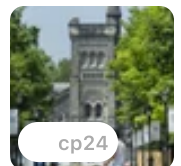
134 upvotes · 44 comments



r/UPenn • 2mo ago

What are the best and worst dorms for first years?

15 upvotes · 15 comments



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release

12 comments

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Dorm room ideas

4 comments

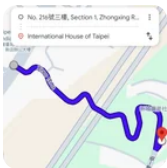
PROMOTED



 r/bicycling • 4d ago

The last 850m to my dorm are 13% going up a hill. Will I regret buying a (road or gravel) bicycle for commuting ?

179 upvotes · 157 comments



 r/Resume • 27d ago

I've been mentoring some new grads on resume writing lately, and there are a few things you really need to avoid if you're fresh out of school and looking for your first big job.

8 upvotes · 3 comments

 r/studentsph • 2y ago

Dorm Essentials and helpful tips?

13 upvotes · 11 comments

 r/Towson • 26d ago

Dorm move out / trash picking?

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prepping for dorm life soon - what do you wish you knew before moving in?

21 upvotes · 43 comments

[r/college](#) • 4y ago

I move into college in 1 week. Any move in day tips for an incoming freshman?

17 upvotes · 12 comments

[r/BinghamtonUniversity](#) • 2mo ago

What are my chances in getting a single dorm room as a Freshman?

2 upvotes · 11 comments

[r/HongKong](#) • 7mo ago

Dorms at EduHK

2 upvotes · 2 comments

[r/Msstate](#) • 26d ago

Are there any other incoming freshman who are moving into a single dorm Fall Semester? 😊

5 upvotes · 14 comments

[r/CalPoly](#) • 2mo ago

Dorm Recommendations for an Incoming freshman

3 upvotes · 25 comments

[r/UPenn](#) • 1mo ago

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9 upvotes · 8 comments

[r/boulder](#) • 1mo ago

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14 upvotes · 38 comments

[r/django](#) • 1y ago

dorm: Django wrapper that lets you use its ORM in standalone manner

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9 upvotes · 9 comments



r/CalPoly · 2mo ago

How does picking freshman dorms work?

6 upvotes · 3 comments



r/cuboulder · 1y ago

What are you guys like?

5 upvotes · 44 comments



r/cuboulder · 13d ago

Dorms were the best time of my life that I would not want to re-live.

79 upvotes · 12 comments

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